

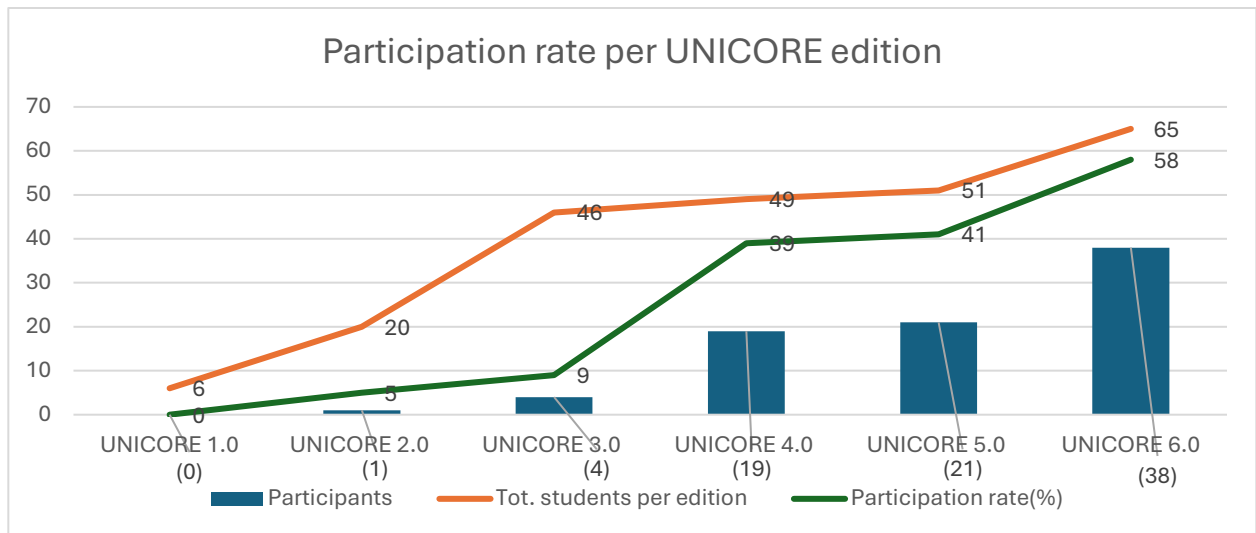
Enhancing the UNICORE Experience

Insights and Recommendations from the 2025 Student Survey

UNICORE 1.0-6.0 survey has been conducted to better understand **where UNHCR could improve in meeting** refugee students' **needs**. The survey also provides input on **where we have opportunities to improve** and strengthen the way we engage and collaborate focusing on **participation, level of appreciation** and **empowerment**.

UNHCR launched the survey to **students** at the beginning of March 2025 and it ran for 10 working days. The target group was the whole group of UNICORE **students and former students (189)** still in Italy, from the 6 editions of the project.

A total of 83 students (see below number of respondents, distinguished by UNICORE edition) contributed to the survey (44% of the invitees), representing various editions of the UNICORE project, as follows. The survey aimed to gather feedback on different aspects of their experience with the project and identify areas for improvement.



Level of Appreciation

Students expressed a good level of appreciation for the project and key aspects have been evaluated as follows:

Main Aspects of UNICORE (Students 6.0)



The survey results provide valuable insights into students' perceptions of the core support services offered by the UNICORE programme. Among the ten main aspects evaluated by UNICORE 6.0 cohort, the **selection process (interview)** received the highest level of appreciation, with **60.5% of respondents rating it as "Very good"**. Similarly, **support received during the pre-departure phase** and **reception and post-arrival support** were highly valued, with **52.6%** of respondents rating each as "Very good", reflecting the programme's strength in preparing and welcoming students.

The **support from local organizations** also stood out, with **44.7% "Very good"** ratings, followed by **support during the application phase** and **access to documentation**, both at **42.1%**. The **dissemination of the project among refugee communities** received **31.6% "Very good"**, while **academic remote tutorship** and **post-arrival academic orientation** were rated "Very good" by **28.9%** of respondents.

The **Italian language course provided remotely** received the lowest "Very good" rating at **23.7%**, suggesting this area may benefit from targeted improvements. Overall, the findings

highlight strong appreciation for the programme's core services, while also identifying opportunities to enhance language support and academic guidance.

Students provided feedback on their experience with the **UNICORE website**, not reporting any specific difficulties in applying for UNICORE 6.0 (first edition using a unique application form).

Feedback from UNICORE 6.0 students indicates a **generally positive experience with the digital tools and information provided during the application process**. On a scale from 1 (very unclear/difficult) to 5 (very clear/easy), the clarity of university calls for applications received an average rating of 4.34, while the clarity of course information and the ease of navigating the new UNICORE website both averaged 4.11. The experience of applying for a university course through the platform was similarly rated positively, with a mean score of 4.18. These findings suggest that the majority of students found the digital interface and informational content accessible and supportive. Nevertheless, a small number of students reported lower scores, highlighting the need for continued improvements in consistency, user experience, and multilingual accessibility to ensure equitable access for all applicants, regardless of their digital literacy or language background.

Students from the UNICORE 6.0 cohort reported discovering the project through a diverse range of communication channels. The most frequently cited sources were **UNHCR offices and partner organizations** (8 students), followed closely by **informal networks such as friends** (7 students) and **social media platforms** (6 students). Several students also mentioned combinations of these channels, including the **UNICORE website, community awareness meetings, and advertisements in other media**. This variety underscores the importance of a **multi-channel outreach strategy** to ensure broad and inclusive access to information, particularly for refugee populations who may rely on both formal and informal networks to learn about educational opportunities.

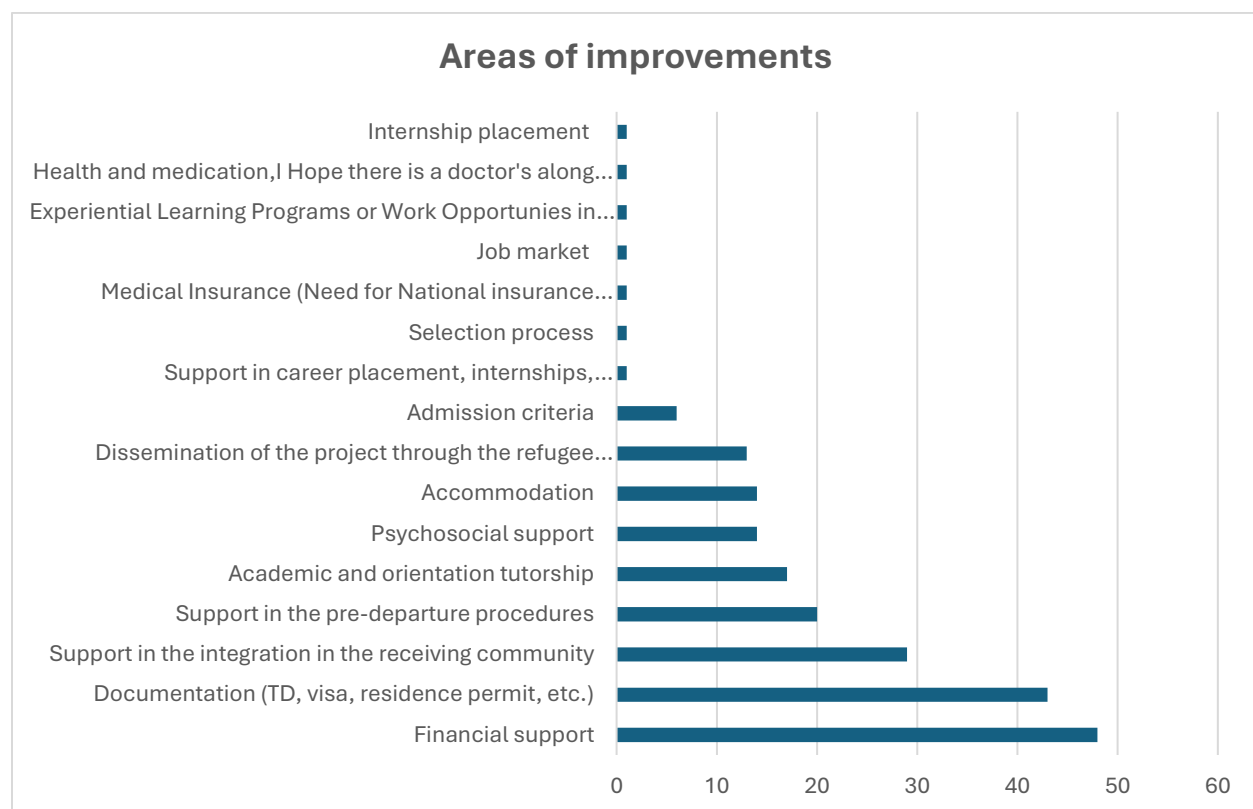
The majority of students from the UNICORE 6.0 cohort indicated that the **information provided about the project's terms and scholarship opportunities** was clear, accessible, and comprehensive. Among the 38 respondents, the most common response was "Agree," indicating a general satisfaction with the communication materials shared prior to and during the application process. This suggests that the majority of students felt well-informed and adequately prepared to engage with the program. However, the presence of varied responses also points to a need for further refinement in how information is disseminated, ensuring that all students—regardless of background or language proficiency—receive consistent and exhaustive guidance. Enhancing clarity and accessibility remains essential to fostering trust and enabling informed participation in the program.

Areas for Improvement

Students identified some areas for improvement, the most frequently cited themes include **financial support**, **documentation** (TD, visa, residence permit, etc.), and **support in the integration in the receiving community**. These themes were mentioned by a significant number of students, indicating their importance in the overall student experience.

Financial support was the most frequently mentioned area, with 48 students highlighting the need for increased financial assistance to cover living expenses, tuition fees, and other essential costs. **Documentation issues**, including delays in obtaining TDs, visas, and residence permits, were mentioned by 43 students, emphasizing the need for streamlined and efficient processes. **Support in the inclusion in the receiving community** was cited by 29 students, underscoring the importance of providing resources and assistance to help students adapt to their new environment.

Other areas for improvement included **support in the pre-departure procedures** (20 mentions), **academic and orientation tutorship** (17 mentions), and **psychosocial support** (14 mentions). These findings highlight the need for comprehensive support systems that address the diverse needs of UNICORE students.



Participants shared their recommendations through free text considerations, highlighting several key issues related to the **financial support** and overall experience of students under the UNICORE program¹.

Despite 74% of respondents indicating that they receive adequate means and resources to carry out their studies, one of the primary concerns is the **rising cost of living** in Italy, which significantly impacts students, especially those in large cities like Rome. There is a call for **uniform financial and accommodation support** across all universities and suggestions to increase **partnership with private sector companies** for internships and job opportunities.

Students also face challenges with **taxation** on their stipends, which are already insufficient to cover essential expenses such as rent, health insurance, and food. Students recommends **exempting them from taxes**, as it is already foreseen by the program, and **increasing financial support** to alleviate these burdens. Additionally, there are issues with the **timely provision of scholarships** and the lack of effective **medical support by local health services**. Namely, some UNICORE students reported significant challenges related to healthcare access and support. Common concerns include the lack of adequate medical insurance, the need to pay for medications out-of-pocket, and the absence of dedicated medical assistance within the program. Some students suggested integrating national health insurance coverage and providing direct access to doctors. Others emphasized that poor health support negatively affects their ability to study and adapt, especially during the initial months in Italy.

Health-related concerns are also prominent, with recommendations to improve the **healthcare system** for students and to implement **psychosocial monitoring** to better understand their integration challenges.

The **duration of the scholarship** is deemed insufficient, with suggestions to extend it to three years, including time (e.g. a foundation year) for learning the Italian language.

Integration and post-graduation support are critical, with students expressing uncertainty about their future in Italy. There is a need for clearer **integration pathways** for refugees, **mentorship programs**, and **networking opportunities** with alumni. The comments also emphasize the importance of **career guidance** and **job placement support** post-graduation.

Documentation issues, such as delays in obtaining **residence permits** and **CTDs** by relevant Immigration Offices, are highlighted, with calls for better coordination and clarity in

¹ The comprehensive list of quotes is available at Annex 1.

the process. Finally, the input provided by students suggests **regular meetings with stakeholders** and the inclusion of student representatives to address ongoing issues effectively.

Another area of concern involves the **project partners**. The comments provided underscore the need to improve **coordination among partners** and to develop documents that clearly define the roles and responsibilities of each partner in supporting UNICORE students. Many students are unaware of who is responsible for what among the partners involved, leading to confusion and inefficiency. Additionally, it is recommended that the UNHCR take responsibility for periodically checking with participating universities and partners to ensure they are delivering the promised services to students.

Overall, the document underscores the need for **enhanced financial support**, better **healthcare and integration services**, and more robust **post-graduation support** to ensure the success and well-being of UNICORE students, along with more effective **coordination among project partners**.

Involvement and Communication

The majority of students confirmed that they understood the objectives of UNICORE and received adequate means and resources to carry out their studies. However, some students reported delays in receiving course materials and laptops, as well as weak internet connections, impacting their ability to study properly.

Most of them were aware about the creation of an UNICORE Committee (80%) and the survey represented also the opportunity to further share the invitation for students to join the Committee through a dedicated WhatsApp group (<https://chat.whatsapp.com/CoiznhRhMCMFzGkqhbah5S>).



Relationships and Conflictuality

While many students expressed a good level of appreciation for relationships within university and local communities, some students reported experiencing bullying and unfair behaviors during their participation in the UNICORE project. These incidents highlight the need to strengthen local efforts to ensure reliable communication channels and address discriminatory behaviors promptly. Here are some quotes from the students:

- "Some racism was experienced. In a dormitory, an Italian student used to harass me because of skin color."
- "Where I'm staying, the environment isn't welcoming for black students; indeed there's something like racism."
- "People avoid sitting next to me on the train; some students were not happy to study with a black student but changed their behavior after months."

Concluding Remarks

The survey results indicate a generally **positive reception of the UNICORE project** among students, with **high levels of appreciation for various aspects of the program**.

Worth noting that all respondents recommend the expansion of UNICORE projects to other countries in Europe and recommend this opportunity to other refugees seeking scholarship opportunities in the future.

However, the feedback also highlights several areas that require attention and improvement. The issues concerning financial need and post-graduation support, along with concerns expressed on bullying and unfair behaviors, as well as the need for enhanced psychological support are critical and must be addressed to ensure a safe and supportive environment for all students.

For what concerns accountability related issues, **65 students** (approximately 78% of respondents) stated that they were able to **easily communicate** with universities and project partners about challenges they faced. However, **9 students (around 11%)** reported difficulties in doing so. Their concerns included **unclear communication channels, lack of responsiveness from coordinators, and uncertainty about whom to contact**. These findings suggest that while the majority feel supported, a significant minority experience gaps in communication and accountability that should be addressed to ensure equitable support for all participants.

Recommendations

Based on the survey results, the following recommendations are proposed to enhance the UNICORE project:

- **Improve Post-Graduation Support:** Develop programs to support students in their transition to the workforce, including job placement services, mentorships, internships, and networking opportunities. Consider a grace period support during this transition.
- **Strengthen Documentation Processes:** Streamline the processes for obtaining and renewing documentation, such as residence permits and CTD, to reduce delays and ensure students can focus on their studies.
- **Increase Financial Support:** Recognize the rising cost of living and the financial challenges faced by students. Effectively exempt students from taxes on their scholarships, ensure timely provision of scholarships, and consider harmonizing financial and accommodation support across all universities.
- **Improve Coordination Among Partners:** Enhance the coordination among project partners by developing clear agreement documents that define the roles and responsibilities of each partner in supporting UNICORE students. Ensure that all partners are aware of their duties and are held accountable for delivering the promised services. UNHCR should periodically check with participating universities and partners to ensure compliance and effective service delivery.
- **Address Bullying and Discrimination:** Implement measures to prevent and address bullying and discriminatory behaviors. Establish clear communication channels for students to report incidents and ensure prompt action is taken.
- **Enhance Psychological Support:** Provide comprehensive psychological support services to help students cope with stress and challenges. Implement regular monitoring to assess students' well-being and integration.

ANNEX 1

Financial Support and Scholarships

- "The **rising cost of living in Italy** has a certain impact on the way students study, especially for those living in large cities. Please note that not all students have the same benefits, depending on where they study and the organization hosting them."
- "Students under Unicare scholarships **should be exempted from paying taxes** because they don't have any regular sources of income for instance, in my university, we are to pay a tax of 156 euros every year and it's renewable, the stipends are taxed and the net amount of money given isn't sufficient to cover the costs such as rent, health insurance, feeding, upkeep to mention but a few."
- "Harmonise both **financial and accommodation support** offered to students in all universities. Consider partnering with private sector companies for both internships and jobs to unicare students."
- "I strongly recommend increasing the **financial support** especially for students who are in Rome city because of high standards living."
- "**No timely provision of stipends** and no medical insurance policy."
- "Uniform **payment** across universities."
- "Unicare could help with **financial support** to students who are in the pre-departure process."
- "My recommendation could be if possible all the universities participating in UNICORE project to **streamline all the stipends and benefits** given on the scholarship package."

Health

- "In Italy the **department in charge of people's health should be improved**, we can not study well when we're sick and we don't get help. 2. the allowance is low there should be increments. 3. The duration period of the scholarship is not enough it should be 3 years including 6 months studying Italian language before attending classes and then 6 months for Research."
- "I recommend, if possible, that **psychosocial monitoring** be implemented for students to understand their level of integration and the challenges they face in the academic environment, especially in the first year. On the other hand, I recommend

adopting a way to **investigate what causes most students not to graduate in record time and the reasons dropout** (if such cases exist)."

- "More efforts should be focused on psychological support upon arrival in Italy."
- "I recommend implementing psychosocial monitoring for students to understand their level of integration and challenges faced."
- "Could be best if the issues on Documentation, bureaucracy, borsa di studio(financial support) and the psychological guidance and counseling."
- "**National Health Insurance.**"

Local Partnerships

- "**Project partners** should try to meet their engagement."
- "**Partnership need to be improved.** There is a need for partners involved in each city to develop agreement document on what's role of party supporting UNICORE students like role and responsibilities. In most case, many students don't know who is doing what from partners involved."
- "Some of the **benefits** attached to the scholarship are not taken into account by the responsible partners of the project."
- "No medical insurance, failure of **partners** to deliver on their promised services."
- "It'd be great if UNHCR takes up the responsibility(a **field visit once in a while**) of cross-checking with the participating universities and partners on the services delivery, especially on the question of 'are universities/partners delivering what they promised they would?'"
- "Improvement of the **coordination amongst partners.**"

Documentation (pre-departure and in Italy)

- "More clarity on the **submission of motivation letters** as they are directed to different universities."
- "Many students still struggling with the problems of **passport or CTD** because the immigration officers do not want to release them on time. Also to get the permit of stay it taking too much time."
- "Confusion on **DOV Vs Translated documents**; There should be uniformity to all universities in the project, But also the period of 2Yrs for this project is not enough please."

- "To put the process of getting **CIMEA documents** in the hands of FCA as I appreciated the way they are helping the students to get DoV document. Based on the date of departure, the students should get a lot information of the airports they are passing through."
- "In general UNICORE project is very good especially in supporting us refugee through education, however I would request to support students on pre departure sessions because students get delayed during the process of acquiring **CTDs and visa** and reach here when the semester had began and miss some lectures, so if unicare can support students and reach here in Italy before the semester begins it would be a good achievement, otherwise am very grateful for the initiative and support u always give us."
- **"CTDS and resident permit."**
- "Longivity of **residence permit** appointment that takes more than 10 months in some areas of Veneto should be addressed and also students should be assigned mentors to help them cope with the system easily."
- "The program is well organized and life changing to both refugees and their families. However the refugees usually face **documentation problems** right after they graduate. It would be ideal if there could be services that target this issue."
- "Students generally need to be given **educational orientation** regarding Italian system of teaching methods and also some places **residence permit takes more than ten months** to be processed or appointment of such lengths needs to be addressed if possible."
- "I recommend contacting the immigration authorities to facilitate the issuing of the **residence permit** because it is usually late."

Integration and Post-graduation support

- "UNICORE project helps in empowering us in education and giving us an opportunity to expand career wise but in regards to **life after school it's pretty unclear and unfair** seeing we are from countries where we are refugees and expected to work as internationals here if we want to continue or pause life for a certain period to be evaluated as a refugee here which can be complicated as that's not an option as we have to work in order to live. The options handed to us makes us easily live as refugees of our former countries for life if we want to stay. I believe there should an **integration to Italy as refugees seeing as we are clearly educated we can actually bring**

something to the table if that was a worry and if I'm wrong about the information I have there should be a clear communication in regards to it, as **it's very discouraging to study not being ascertain of your stay in the country and knowing going back is also not an option** as it wasn't also better where you are from."

- "The accommodation, Financial support, inclusion activities. (proposal: inclusion of **links to jobs after completion of studies and a grace period before self autonomy after studies**)."
- "Expanding **labour mobility opportunities** for UNICORE (University Corridors for Refugees) students beyond Italy can significantly enhance their career prospects."
- "I needed a **mentor to guide me** on some things regarding adaptation to the new academic environment but haven't got one I hope the upcoming generations will be provided with mentors at all universities even us UNICORE 6 universities without such programs need to have as soon as possible to guide us towards better completion without struggles."
- "**Networking between the Alumni and the current students**, More activities to amplify UNICORE Project, Career Day for refugee graduates."
- "**Tutor buddies** should be from the same department of the new student."
- "Creation of **Employment** for students seeking jobs."
- "Personally I don't know what will be my next if I spend 3 years due to the challenge of language while the scholarship is for 2 years! Otherwise for the moment everything is okay. I'm just wondering about **the future**."
- "(1) Unicare program needs to support students with **internship and job opportunities**, (2) all unicare project partners who are in charge with accommodation or other supports to students should provide students with **food cards or gift cards for food stuffs** as Centro Astali does to the students that they support."
- "I would recommend the UNICORE team **to expand this program** and also increase the number of students to be admitted in different Universities hence expanding the opportunities to many students."
- "Close follow up and support in **job placement** post graduation."
- "Increasing the **number of scholars per institution** will create more opportunities for students."

Italian Language

- "I'm a student at Roma Tre University and I encountered a serious problem. In the scholarship it was indicated that knowledge of the **Italian's language** was not compulsory to apply for the UNICORE's scholarship, upon arrived in Italy unfortunately I found that my department doesn't organize an English program and because I don't know the Italian's language I'm taking the examens of courses that I didn't participate to. Surly it's very stressful. Kindly think about it."
- "It's very stressful to do the master the way I'm doing it, there inform ours universities that the program should be taught in English. **Italian's language** itself can take 3 years to learn it while the program of the project (UNICORE) is for two years."
- "The opportunity to study the **Italian course** online should be offered all year round."

Participation

- "I suggest that UNHCR should once in while organize **student get togethers** in order to create channels for networking and I also believe students should be support in finding internship places."
- "**Career and future empowerment**, how to grow and develop in Italy both professionally and mentally, this can be done through **career guidance sessions** maybe in the second year of study for those who wish to stay in Italy, this could be virtual, talking about opportunities available and how to capitalize on them, an annual conference for **all continuing unicare students to meet once a year**, share their experience and progress, get to meet with partners and donors and probably invited unicare alumni as guest speakers to share testimonials, this could foster understanding of project objective to all students. **Such a conference once a year would be helpful.**"
- "A **regular meeting with the stakeholders** would be great to address issues faced by students in a timely manner and get response at a higher level."
- "I would suggest that you **include a representative from each university under the unicare student committee.**"
- "Let there be a **committed focal person to solve students problem** which they face on a daily basis."